Title (draft)

Untangling identification and verification across a bank's branch, telephony, app and web channels — mid-merger, with no single source of truth to work from.

1. "**Unifying multi channel identification and verification processes in a bank**"
2. "Redesigning identity verification across four channels of a bank mid-merger."
3. "Mapping and unifying a fragmented identity verification process during a bank merger."
4. "**Bringing one consistent identity verification process to a multi-channel, merging bank**."
5. "Untangling identity verification across a merging bank's branch, telephony and digital channels."
6. **One identity, three channels that didn't agree**

1. One Identity, Everywhere
2. Verify Once, Everywhere
3. One Unified Identity
4. Same You, Everywhere
5. **One Identity, Unified**

Service Design · Workstream Owner · `Concepts delivered, not shipped` · `5 months` · `Financial Services · B2C` · `Legacy systems`

The Problem

Virgin Money was mid-merger with NBS (Nationwide Building Society), and identification & verification — the process that confirms who a customer is before letting them transact — had grown fragmented across the bank's channels. Branch, telephony, app and web each handled ID&V differently, with no unified view of a customer's verification status across them. A customer verified in one channel often had to re-verify from scratch in another.

The scale of the friction was real: an early analysis of 1000+ customer complaints surfaced ID&V as a recurring source of frustration across channels.

The deeper problem was no single source of truth existed for how ID&V actually worked. That had to be reconstructed — independently within each channel, and collectively across them — largely from SME knowledge, not existing documentation. Some of this reconstruction ran in parallel with other, undocumented ID&V work already in flight elsewhere in the organisation, which you had to identify and account for rather than duplicate.

The Challenge

1. Bring consistency to a fragmented experience.
One ID&V process, understood and applied the same way, regardless of which channel a customer walked into.

2. Protect the customers merger complexity puts most at risk.
Older and less digitally-confident customers were most exposed to inconsistent branch identification across the two merging entities — simplifying this mattered more for them than for anyone else.

3. Make telephony ID&V less costly to run.
Every unnecessary re-verification in telephony was time, and time was operational cost and, dissatisfied customers

My Role

Service Designer, owning the ID&V workstream largely independently, reporting to Darren Moran (Design Manager)

__Team__: __Tom__, (customer journey specialist) — built the app and web ID&V blueprints from a baseline Virgin Money's own team had already produced; you reviewed and corrected these for service design rigor. __Mupi,__ junior service designer — turned your content into weekly progress decks, scheduled sessions, took notes on research calls. __Alicia Martin__ — planning structure, stakeholder-navigation coaching, positioning support with the client as Accenture.

__What you owned end to end__:
- Service blueprinting branch and telephony ID&V — creating the source of truth that didn't exist
- SME identification and interviews across the business — building the right participant list to surface how ID&V actually worked
- Cross-verification of every blueprint with the SMEs who ran the process
- Curating, designing, and facilitating three channel-specific ideation sessions
- Synthesising ideation output into a single cross-channel concept
- Running the concept development session and scoring the resulting concepts against SME input
- Workstream management and reporting

Turning Discovery into Ideas — Channel by Channel

Rather than one mixed-channel session, you ran three separate ideation sessions — Telephony, Branch, Digital — each one you curated and facilitated, so channel-specific friction could surface on its own terms before being asked to converge into anything shared. Between them, the sessions produced 40+ ideas across the three channels [PPT]**.

From that output, plus what you knew was already in flight elsewhere, plus the group's own additions, you synthesised a single unifying concept: one ID&V identity usable across products, with step-up verification only when a customer's risk tier actually changed.

You then ran a follow-on concept development session — **four ideation and concept development workshops in total [PPT]** — and rather than scoring the resulting concepts by team consensus alone, you took the scoring (impact vs. effort) back to SMEs in each channel to check it against how those teams actually experienced the friction day to day.

How I worked

****Reconstructing the as-is, channel by channel****
You personally mapped the branch and telephony ID&V journeys — five separate telephony service blueprints alone (balance enquiry, bill payment, transaction enquiry, update email address, and related queries), plus the branch/store journey — each built by talking directly to SMEs across the business to understand how the process actually ran, then looping back with them to confirm the map was accurate before treating it as ground truth.

****Running the room**, not just contributing to it****
You curated who needed to be in each session, shaped what a 1.5–2 hour ideation session would cover, and facilitated all three — Telephony, Branch, and Digital — separately, so channel-specific friction could surface on its own terms before being merged into anything cross-channel.

****Synthesising across channels, then testing it against reality****
From the three ideation sessions, plus what you knew was already in flight elsewhere, plus the group's own additions, you synthesised a single unifying concept: one ID&V identity usable across products and channels, with step-up verification only when risk tier actually changed. You then ran a follow-on concept development session, and rather than scoring the resulting three concepts (impact vs. effort) by team consensus alone, you went back to SMEs in each channel — branch, telephony, digital — to validate the scoring against how those teams actually experienced the friction.

****Keeping stakeholders inside the process, weekly****
You produced weekly progress decks — progress, blockers, next steps — so the client and Accenture leadership had continuous visibility rather than a single end-of-project reveal.

The Solution

Three concepts came out of that process, each scored on customer impact and business effort, each with a short-term (3-month) and long-term (3-year) plan:

****1. Awareness of ID&V questions and documents required.****
Customers and colleagues alike often didn't know, in advance, what a given verification step would ask for. Surfacing this upfront reduces failed attempts and repeat contact.

****2. Unification of customer ID&V across Virgin Money.****
One ID&V identity, usable across products and channels — a customer verified at Tier 2 doesn't start from zero if a Tier 3 product asks for more, they only provide the incremental information the higher tier requires.

****3. Consistent language frameworks across channels and colleagues.****
The same question, asked the same way, whether a customer is on the phone, in branch, or in the app — removing a subtle but real source of confusion and mistrust.

****4+ concepts with a 3-month and 3-year plan [PPT]** were delivered to the client, with an accountable owner identified to carry them into implementation.

Reaching Past Scope

Any real unification concept had to account for both merging entities, not just Virgin Money's side. So you reached out to NBS's own design team — not something formally scoped, but necessary if the concept was going to hold up.

They couldn't answer. Key people were on leave, and NBS's ID&V process wasn't documented in enough detail for their own team to explain how it would integrate post-merger. That's not a dead end in the story — it's a finding. It surfaced something the client may not have had visibility into: the two entities weren't yet in a position to say how their ID&V processes would actually meet in the middle. The unification concept had to be designed around that uncertainty, not in ignorance of it.

Where It Stands

Designs and concepts were completed; the workstream wasn't shipped or moved into development before the engagement ended. As a service design engagement, the goal was to surface solutions and hand them to someone accountable for building them — that handoff happened, with three scored concepts and their implementation plans in the client's hands.

Learnings

1. Discovery is load-bearing, not a preamble.
When no one has documented how a process actually works, finding that out — SME by SME, validation loop by validation loop — isn't the step before the real design work. It is the real design work.

2. Structure the room before you ask it a question.
Three separate channel sessions before one converged concept meant channel-specific friction got heard on its own terms, instead of being flattened by whichever voice was loudest in a mixed room.

3. A finding you can't resolve is still a finding.
The NBS wall didn't get designed away. Naming it clearly — rather than quietly working around it — gave the client something real to act on, which is arguably more useful than a concept that pretended the merger wasn't still unresolved.

Write other learnings

- Importance of a shared visible plan in the beginning
- Documenting one’s own work weekly
- Adapting to cultural differences - Mupi showing her work vs mine (metrics over matter)
- Asking for help
- Course correction of scope
- SD’s role when working in a transient phase (service over product)

Thanks

With thanks to Alicia Martin, Tom, and Mupi — and the SMEs across branch, telephony, and digital who gave the time to validate every blueprint and every score.

[OPEN: keep, cut, or trim to fewer names — your call, especially once scrubbing happens.]

Notes on what's still open

1. Title — pick from A–D above, or none of them.
2. [PPT]-flagged numbers (1000+ complaints, 10+ hrs SME interviews, 9 blueprints/3 months, 40+ ideas, 4 workshops, 4+ concepts) — confirm these are fair to state as your workstream's activity, not the wider programme's.
3. Goals — same "on hold" status as v1.
4. Learnings — placeholder reflections written in my voice; want these closer to yours, or additions.
5. Visuals — not yet mapped; next step once you pick a structure (v1 or v2) to run with.